

7. You can demand a better deal.

APR too high? Hate the annual fee? Want a longer grace period? It turns out your credit card company may just have to do your bidding. See, the fees they charge are not considered a necessary cost of doing business, so you can request, firmly, that they be reduced or eliminated. Now, imagine what would happen if we all did that? No wonder they want that one kept secret. And remember, if all else fails, find a lower-cost APR card and transfer your balance. You have at least that going for you.

That's the scoop folks. If you happen to be in spiraling credit card debt, there are places you can go to for help. PBS.org has a great list of resources. From now on, I hope you all look a whole lot closer at that handy piece of plastic in your wallet. It's far more ominous than it first looks. Pleasant dreams, everyone. — **Paul Michael**

What Credit Counselors Do and How to Pick One

So you are up to your eyeballs, drowning in debt and expenses, and struggling to keep your head above water. You have been reduced to the life of a monk and are still making no headway. Is it time to see a credit counselor?

First, let's take a look at the typical symptoms that may require credit counseling:

1. You use credit cards to pay for groceries and other household expenses because you don't have the cash.
2. You don't even know how much debt you owe anymore.
3. You use one credit card to pay off another.
4. You use cash advances as the only way to get some cash.
5. You are denied when you ask for an increase in your credit limit.
6. You ask for a credit increase in the first place because you think it will help you manage your expenses.